

First Read

Tencent Holdings

NDR takeaway: AI investments for long-term upside

We hosted a NDR meeting with Tencent mgmt Mr. Martin Lau (President), Mr. James Mitchell (CSO) and Mr. John Lo (CFO). The discussions primarily centered on AI, covering agentic AI and monetization, in which long-term opportunities could be best captured by Tencent, in our view. Trading at 14x 2026e P/E and with expectations reset, we believe Tencent's solid core businesses' performance and longer-term AI upside optionality are underappreciated. Reiterate Tencent as our [Key Call](#) and top pick.

Agentic AI: Opportunity likely best positioned for Tencent

AI progression: We note OpenClaw could represent an initial form in which humans can interact with AI to enhance productivity. Going forward, AI should continue to evolve from communication and reasoning toward more action-oriented applications. This should gradually play into Tencent's strength, given its robust ecosystem (Weixin and QQ serving as the communication layer, a natural interface between humans and AI), cross-platform capabilities (mobile and PC), as well as expertise in product and security software across terminals. **Weixin agent:** Current bottlenecks are threefold: 1) limited model ability to effectively handle complex use cases, which mgmt sees no readily available models globally at present, 2) concerns over data privacy and security, and 3) the economic model (given high variable inference cost but challenges in monetizing through subscription). Yuanbao would be the testing ground for AI functionalities.

AI monetization: Long-term benefits from sustained ecosystem enhancement

Overall, mgmt takes a comprehensive view on monetization, positioning the HY foundation model as an enabling layer to facilitate broader ecosystem growth, rather than focusing on direct monetization of the model itself. With the Weixin agent expected to further increase user engagement within the ecosystem, this should create monetization opportunities from enhanced payment, transactions (Mini Shops take rate), and ad revenue. With that, the key priorities remain integrating AI into products and infrastructure, echoing the earlier approach that drove success in Tencent's payment and cloud businesses as market conditions mature. Additionally, Tencent has already achieved high ROI from existing ad and games businesses by leveraging AI.

LLM: HY 3.0 and model direction

Timing and expectation: HY 3.0 is expected to be launched in mid-Apr, and to mark the most significant advancement in Tencent's past model iterations. Mgmt emphasizes that the model's capabilities, while important, are secondary to establishing a robust

Equities

China
Internet Services

12-month rating **Buy**

12m price target **HK\$780.00**

Price (20 Mar 2026) **HK\$508.00**

RIC: 0700.HK BBG: 700 HK

Trading data and key metrics

52-wk range	HK\$677.50-435.40
Market cap.	HK\$4,716b/US\$602b
Shares o/s	9,284m (ORD)
Free float	66%
Avg. daily volume ('000)	26,986
Avg. daily value (m)	HK\$15,265.3
Common s/h equity (12/25E)	Rmb1154b
P/BV (12/25E)	3.6x
Net debt to EBITDA (12/25E)	0.0x

EPS (UBS, diluted) (Rmb)

	UBS	Cons.
12/25E	28.09	27.89
12/26E	32.04	31.44
12/27E	36.03	35.06

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Highlights (Rmbm)	12/22	12/23	12/24	12/25E	12/26E	12/27E	12/28E	12/29E
Revenues	554,552	609,015	660,257	751,766	848,830	931,371	1,008,886	1,091,887
EBIT (UBS)	151,795	205,694	253,815	297,565	329,486	369,977	406,545	445,818
Net earnings (UBS)	115,649	157,688	222,703	259,626	293,184	329,774	363,308	399,372
EPS (UBS, diluted) (Rmb)	11.93	16.41	23.67	28.09	32.04	36.03	39.70	43.64
DPS (net) (Rmb)	2.39	3.46	4.57	5.39	6.15	6.92	7.62	8.38
Net (debt) / cash	(70,065)	13,503	(9,785)	(2,914)	173,535	376,456	606,488	874,438
Profitability/valuation	12/22	12/23	12/24	12/25E	12/26E	12/27E	12/28E	12/29E
EBIT (UBS) margin %	27.4	33.8	38.4	39.6	38.8	39.7	40.3	40.8
ROIC (EBIT) %	25.3	34.3	37.2	35.8	36.8	41.3	45.4	50.2
EV/EBITDA (UBS core) x	12.3	10.1	9.3	10.7	9.4	8.4	7.6	6.9
P/E (UBS, diluted) x	24.7	18.5	14.0	16.7	14.0	12.4	11.2	10.2
Equity FCF (UBS) yield %	3.5	6.2	5.5	4.2	6.6	7.3	8.2	9.2
Dividend yield (net) %	0.8	1.1	1.4	1.2	1.4	1.5	1.7	1.9

Source: Company accounts, LSEG Eikon, UBS estimates. Metrics marked as (UBS) have had analyst adjustments applied. Valuations: based on an average share price that year, (E): based on a share price of HK\$ 508.00 on 20-Mar-2026

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model production framework. This encompasses the team, workflows, data, model architecture, training infrastructure and evaluation processes, hence should form a virtuous flywheel to accelerate next iterations going forward. **Model direction:** Compared with global SOTA models, we note that Tencent employs a pragmatic strategy, focusing on driving innovation especially in tackling challenges in relation to task execution by Weixin agent, while avoiding excessive investment. Forward directions would be long-term memory and deeper multi-party context handling.

Existing businesses: Solid game and cloud performance

Games: Mgmt perceives AI an enabler rather than a disruptor for online games, in which Tencent has been strongly embracing AI in its game operations. Alongside increased time spent for entertainment, Tencent's games portfolio primarily consists of multi-player PvP gaming, which is more akin to a social network and would be more difficult to be displaced compared with single player games. **Cloud:** Tencent's cloud revenue accelerated in 4Q25, and it achieved Rmb5bn adj. OP for 2025 (or HSD-10% margin). Into 2026, as chip availability improves (especially into 2H), we note mgmt plans to gradually shift gear toward external cloud customers. Tencent cloud's edge stems from 1) its extensive internal usage, which enables operational knowhow that can be leveraged for third parties, and 2) media-stream SaaS offerings with strong price-to-performance attributes, empowered by two-way video capabilities in Weixin and Tencent Meeting.

Forecast returns

Forecast price appreciation	53.5%
Forecast dividend yield	1.2%
Forecast stock return	54.8%
Market return assumption	10.9%
Forecast excess return	43.9%

Company Description

Tencent has the largest online community in China. It was founded with the launch of instant messaging platform QQ but has since grown into a diversified internet company with core focuses on gaming, social media and networking (Weixin/WeChat), fintech (WeChat Pay), cloud computing and digital content. The company also holds a substantial investment portfolio of public and private companies.

Valuation Method and Risk Statement

Our price target is based on sum of the parts.

We believe the key risks for Tencent include: 1) an evolving and intensifying competitive landscape; 2) new business execution; 3) integration of invested companies and businesses; 4) rising costs of traffic acquisition, content and brand promotions; 5) IT system upkeep; 6) expansion into international markets; 7) infringement of intellectual property rights; 8) departures of key management; and 9) regulatory risks.

Quantitative Research Review

UBS Global Research publishes a quantitative assessment of its analysts' responses to certain questions about the likelihood of an occurrence of a number of short term factors in a product known as the 'Quantitative Research Review'. The views for this month can be found below. Views contained in this assessment on a particular stock reflect only the views on those short term factors which are a different timeframe to the 12-month timeframe reflected in any equity rating set out in this note. For previous responses please make reference to (i) previous UBS Global Research reports; and (ii) where no applicable research report was published that month, the Quantitative Research Review which can be found at <https://neo.ubs.com/quantitative>, or contact your UBS sales representative for access to the report or the Quantitative Research Team on ubs-quant-answers@ubs.com. A consolidated report which contains all responses is also available and again you should contact your UBS sales representative for details and pricing or the Quantitative Research Team on the email above.

Tencent Holdings

Question	Response
1. Is the industry structure facing the firm likely to improve or deteriorate over the next six months? Rate on a scale of 1-5 (1 = getting worse, 3 = no change, 5 = getting better, N/A = no view)	4
2. Is the regulatory/government environment facing the firm likely to improve or deteriorate over the next six months? Rate on a scale of 1-5 (1 = getting tougher, 3 = no change, 5 = getting better, N/A = no view)	3
3. Over the last 3-6 months in broad terms have things been improving/no change/getting worse for this stock? Rate on a scale of 1-5 (1 = getting a lot worse, 3 = not much change, 5 = getting a lot better, N/A = no view)	4
4. Relative to the current CONSENSUS EPS forecast, is the next company EPS update likely to lead to: (1 = negative surprise vs consensus, 3 = in-line with consensus, 5 = positive surprise vs consensus expectations, N/A = no view)	4
5. What's driving the difference?	
6. Relative to YOUR current earnings forecast, is there relatively greater risk at the next earnings result of: (1 = downside skew risk to earnings, 3 = equal upside or downside risk to earnings, 5 = upside skew risk to earnings, N/A = no view)	3
7. What's driving the difference?	
8. Is there an upcoming catalyst for the company over the next three months?	No Catalyst
9. Is there an actual or approximate date for the catalyst?	
10. Is the catalyst date an actual or approximate date?	
11. What is the catalyst?	

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12-Month Rating	Definition	Coverage ¹	IB Services ²
Buy	FSR is > 6% above the MRA.	52%	24%
Neutral	FSR is between -6% and 6% of the MRA.	41%	22%
Sell	FSR is > 6% below the MRA.	7%	25%
Short-Term Rating	Definition	Coverage ³	IB Services ⁴
Buy	Stock price expected to rise within three months from the time the rating was assigned because of a specific catalyst or event.	<1%	<1%
Sell	Stock price expected to fall within three months from the time the rating was assigned because of a specific catalyst or event.	<1%	<1%

Source: UBS. Rating allocations are as of 31 December 2025.

1:Percentage of companies under coverage globally within the 12-month rating category.

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Company Name	Reuters	12-month rating	Price	Price date
Tencent Holdings ^{16,28}	0700.HK	Buy	HK\$508.00	20 Mar 2026

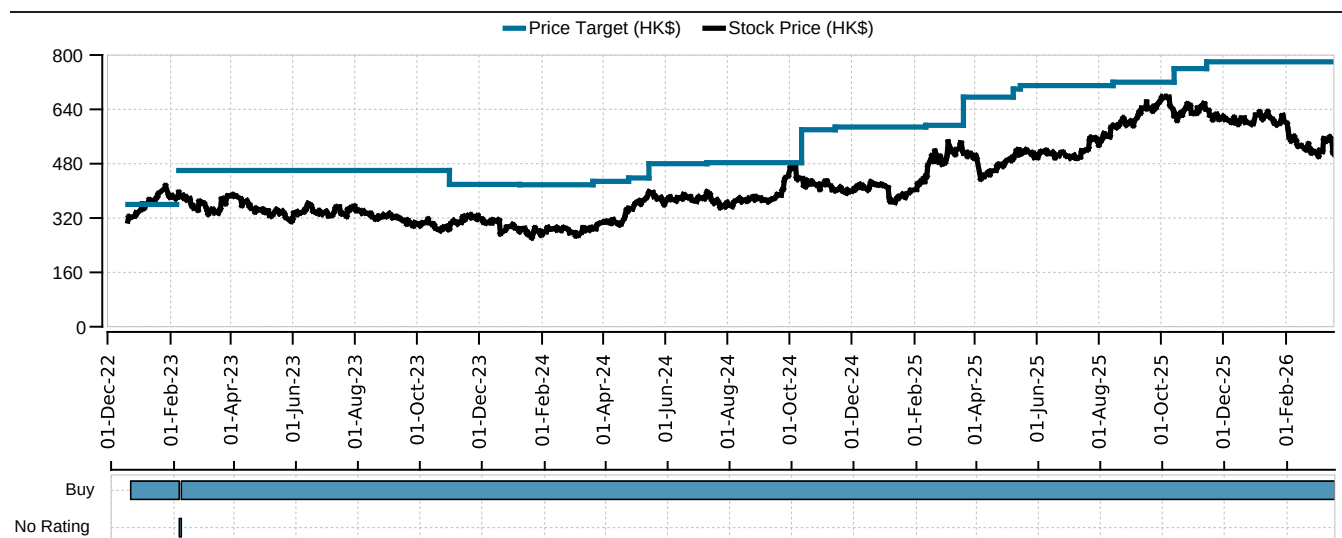
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Tencent Holdings (HK\$)



Date	Stock Price (HK\$)	Price Target (HK\$)	Rating
2022-12-20	309.40	360.00	Buy
2023-02-06	376.80	-	No Rating
2023-02-08	382.20	460.00	Buy
2023-11-01	287.00	419.00	Buy
2024-01-09	283.60	418.00	Buy
2024-03-21	291.20	428.00	Buy

Date	Stock Price (HK\$)	Price Target (HK\$)	Rating
2024-04-25	339.40	438.00	Buy
2024-05-15	381.80	480.00	Buy
2024-07-11	384.80	483.00	Buy
2024-10-12	438.80	580.00	Buy
2024-11-14	403.40	588.00	Buy
2025-02-11	427.40	593.00	Buy
2025-03-20	519.50	676.00	Buy
2025-05-08	498.00	700.00	Buy
2025-05-15	520.00	710.00	Buy
2025-08-14	590.00	720.00	Buy
2025-10-13	639.00	760.00	Buy
2025-11-14	641.00	780.00	Buy

Source: UBS Global Research; LSEG Eikon as of 20-Mar-2026. All prices as of local market close. Ratings as of date shown.

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